TIMES-NEWS

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PAT SUTPHIN, TIMES-NEWS

Ricky Jones, operations manager at Magic Valley Quality Milk Transport, walks out the door as 4,100 gallons of milk pour down the drain Wednesday at the Azevedo Family Dairy in Buhl. With restaurants across the country closed, milk processors have lost a significant chunk of their market, leaving dairy farmers with no one to take their milk. 'It's hard to watch that go down the drain,' owner Richard Azevedo says.

Down the drain

Restaurant closures leaves gaping hole in dairy market

COLIN TIERNAN
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BUHL — The inside of Richard Azevedo's dairy storage building is dark, so you hear the milk before you see it. It sounds like a rushing creek, a small white river gushing out of two massive silver tanks and splashing across a few feet of concrete before disappearing down the drain in the floor.

Azevedo stood outside the building and watched in disbelief as his milk sloshed onto the ground, wasted. There's so much milk to dump that it takes 15 minutes to empty the tanks.

"There's no words," the dairyman said. "That's a day's work. It's hard to watch that go down the drain."

Azevedo was born on a dairy and has been in the business his entire life. He's weathered recessions before, but he's never experienced anything like this.

He has 500 milking cows, and on Wednesday, he had to pour out all 4,200 gallons they produced. He's been forced to dump his milk three times in the past week. That's three times so far he's had to watch roughly $5,000 vanish down the pipe. His revenue has been slashed by 40%.

Please see DRAIN, Page A4

Military wants to build mobile microreactor

KEITH RIDLER
Associated Press

BOISE — The U.S. Department of Defense wants to build a prototype advanced mobile nuclear microreactor at the Idaho National Laboratory in eastern Idaho, saying they are needed to ensure the military's energy supply.

The microreactor would be capable of producing one to 10 megawatts. A megawatt can power from about 400 to 900 homes, depending on energy consumption that is dependent on such things as air conditioning.

The department says it wants to reduce reliance on local electric grids, which are highly vulnerable to prolonged outages from a variety of threats.

The department is considering building the microreactor at the U.S. Department of Energy's Idaho National Laboratory. The Oak Ridge National Laboratory in eastern Tennessee would also take part.

Edwin Lyman, director of Nuclear Power Safety at the Union of Concerned Scientists, a nonprofit, said the project has a goal of creating a portable reactor that can shut down and start up quickly, and doesn't need maintenance or an operator.

"We're talking about paper designs where it would take a long time to develop and demonstrate them to the point where any military commander would actually want to have one on his or her base," Lyman said. "I think

Please see MICROREACTOR, Page A4

Coronavirus forces new approaches to fighting wildfires

REBECCA BOONE
Associated Press

BOISE — They are two disasters that require opposite responses: To save lives and reduce the spread of COVID-19, people are being told to remain isolated. But in a wildfire, thousands of firefighters must work in close quarters for weeks at a time.

Wildfires have already broken out in Texas and Florida, and agencies are scrambling to finish plans for a new approach. They are considering waivers for some training requirements for previously certified crew members and moving some training online.

Other proposals include limiting fire engines to a driver and one passenger, requiring other crew members to ride in additional vehicles. They may scrap the normal campsite catering tents in favor of military-issue MREs — "Meals Ready to Eat" — to reduce touching serving utensils.

Federal resources for firefighting efforts may be more scarce, leaving states to deal with more fires.

In light of the "unprecedented challenge" of the pandemic,

Please see WILDFIRES, Page A4



AP PHOTO/NOAH BERGER, FILE

In this Nov. 26, 2019, file photo, firefighters battle the Cave Fire as it flares up along Highway 154 in the Los Padres National Forest above Santa Barbara, California.

Record 16.8M have sought US jobless aid

ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — With a startling 6.6 million people seeking unemployment benefits last week, the United States has reached a grim landmark: More than one in 10 workers have lost their jobs in just the past three weeks to the coronavirus outbreak.

The figures collectively constitute the largest and fastest string of job losses in records dating to 1948. By contrast, during the Great Recession it took 44 weeks — roughly 10 months — for unemployment claims to go as high as they now have in less than a month.

The damage to job markets is extending across the world. The equivalent of 195 million full-time jobs could be lost in the second quarter to business shutdowns caused by the viral outbreak, according to the United Nations' labor organization. It estimates that global unemployment will rise by 25 million this year. And that doesn't even count workers on reduced hours and pay. Lockdown measures are

Please see JOBLESS, Page A4

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Drain

From A1

Many Magic Valley dairy farmers, and farmers across the U.S., had to dump milk mostly because coronavirus-caused restaurant closures have decimated dairy demand. Restaurants use huge amounts of cheese, butter and cream, and even though sales have increased at grocery stores, that bump isn't nearly enough to make up the difference. About a third of processed milk products go to restaurants.

"We just cannot consume the amount of dairy at home that we did in the foodservice and restaurant industry," said James Carr, director of west coast dairy for FCStone. "That's a tremendous amount of demand just disappearing."

That loss of demand from the foodservice industry trickles down the food chain, leaving Magic Valley dairy processors scrambling to find other buyers and dairy farmers with no one to take their milk. But with the coronavirus pandemic hammering so much of the economy across the entire country, there aren't buyers to be found.

The price of milk has plummeted, so even dairymen who haven't had to dump milk have seen their profits tank. Back in January, a hundred pounds of milk was selling in the $17 range. Now the price is down to around $12 to $13, not much better than back in 2009 when feed prices were lower.

Magic Valley dairymen typically break even at $16.50 per hundredweight, so at today's prices, they're hemorrhaging money.

"If milk stays where it's at for the next two, three months, I don't make it," Azevedo said. "There's just no way."



PAT SUTPHIN TIMES-NEWS

Ricky Jones, operations manager at Magic Valley Quality Milk Transport, opens up the valve of a milk bulk tank Wednesday.

Glimmer of hope gone

Dairy farmers saw the price of milk climb comfortably above the break-even point for the first time in five years this fall. There were several good months in a row, and some dairymen felt like they'd finally be able to profit.

Then the coronavirus pandemic hit.

"For the average dairyman, it's been gut-wrenching," Idaho Dairymen's Association CEO Rick Naerebout said. "We went from looking at 2020 as a year to recover losses from the previous four, to looking at trying to manage one of the greatest downturns our dairymen have faced in their lifetimes.

"And that all happened in a three-week window."

The dairy commodities markets saw some impacts of the coronavirus coming, and that foresight played some role in lower (but still relatively strong) prices from January to mid-March. Then the sheer economic devastation of the virus hit nearly everyone by surprise.

Dairymen, processors and experts said that dairy isn't alone right now in dealing with decreased demand for food products, but there are some unique pains dairy farmers face when they have to throw their milk away.

Just because dairy farmers are earning a fraction of what they used to make selling milk, it doesn't change their daily operations much at all, Azevedo explained. They still have to feed the cows. Even if they know they're going to dump the milk, they still have to milk the cows and pay their employees to run the farm.

Azevedo is part of Magic Valley Quality Milk Producers, a co-op owned by 22 dairy farmers. All of the members of the co-op are in the same situation as Azevedo, taking turns dumping their milk.

Magic Valley Quality Milk Producers CEO Alan Stutzman said the co-op produces 2.7 million pounds of milk a day (about 315,000 gallons). On Wednesday, the co-op had to dump roughly a million pounds of milk.

"We've had some days (in the past week) where we've had to dump 20% of our milk because we don't have a sale," Stutzman said. "I'm worried next week will be even worse."

Other dairy processors have told their farmers they'll be penalized if they produce more milk than their three-year average, and some have said they can't take on as much. A lot of Magic Valley dairymen have avoided having to dump milk so far. But they're worried they might have to at some point.

Buhl dairyman Michael Brubaker said every day the milk truck pulls up to his farm, he worries he'll be told he has to dump milk.

The pandemic is likely to cause a short-term reduction in cows, which could briefly help with the Magic Valley's overproduction issues. The number of cows will probably drop because many farmers, including Azevedo, will have to cull some of their cows — sell them for beef — in order to make some cash and pay their bills.

A lot of beef will hit the market at the same time. The price has already dropped. Azevedo said he'll get only 40 to 50 cents for a pound of beef, down from 70 cents normally.

That ends up costing him between $300 and $400 per animal he sells. Beef producers will be hurt by the drop in price as well.

Different processors have different buyers for their products, so they aren't all being affected exactly the same — but they're all struggling. Idaho Milk Products CEO Daragh Maccabee said his company is working hard to ensure they have risk mitigation procedures in place so that they can continue processing if a significant number of their staff get sick.

On the sales side, he said, Idaho Milk Products is experiencing what all Magic Valley processors are experiencing — retail's up, but cheese, butter and cream are way down.

"So far we've been able to either put it in the warehouse or sell anything we've made," Maccabee said. "We haven't yet as a processor had to dump anything. We're constantly on that edge … We're a day or two away from a situation where that could happen."

Terrible new territory

This is not the first time Magic Valley dairy farmers have had to dump milk.

Stutzman said there was some dumping in 2008.

But back then, the markets adjusted and processors were able to find buyers.

Never before have American farmers had to dump so many millions of gallons of milk down the drain.

Carr explained that every year, America loses between 3% and 7% of its dairies.

He said he expects we'll lose closer to 7% this year. That means the trend of bigger and bigger dairies is going to continue.

"We're getting to fewer and fewer operations, fewer families that are connected to the farm," he said. "So it's kind of a little bit sad."

There are some federal programs, both new and old, that can help dairy farmers stay afloat.

"Folks have to be very lean, very lean in their operations and work with their bankers and also be aware of the federal programs that are coming out," said Hernan Tejeda, a dairy and livestock economist at the University of Idaho Extension.

Magic Valley dairy isn't going to get relief until stay-at-home orders are lifted and restaurants reopen, Carr said. It's hard to know when that will be, but he said he expects that when it happens, diners will turn up in droves and restaurants will bounce back. At the same time, it's unclear how much of a long-term impact the coronavirus will have on peoples' spending habits.

Azevedo said there are a lot of people hurting worse than him right now, and there are worse things than having to dump milk. But he's scared there's a chance he could lose his dairy. And ff that happens, he's worried about taking care of his family.

"You just go to bed at night," he said, "and you just don't know if you're going to have (the farm) tomorrow or not."

Wildfires

From A1

"only when there is a reasonable expectation of success in protecting life and critical property and infrastructure," Forest Service Chief Victoria Christiansen said.

Wildland fire camps have always had a reputation for spreading illness. Norovirus outbreaks have occurred and outbreaks of illnesses collectively dubbed the "camp crud" are yearly occurrences for many. The job is so demanding that it's typically done by younger, healthy and physically fit people. But the nature of the job also works against them: firefighters regularly experiencing high stress, inhaling smoke and dust and dealing with poor sleeping and personal hygiene.

A suck-it-up and tough-it-out culture doesn't help either, said Jessica Gardetto, spokeswoman for the National Interagency Fire Center in Boise, Idaho.

The center coordinates logistics for 14,000 federal firefighters and thousands more state, local and private crews."

"We have really been trying to educate and change that culture because not just in this situation but in others, it's not OK to just tough it out if something's wrong," she said.

You don't have to look too far back in history to see how the one-two punch of a pandemic and wildfire can decimate communities. The 1918 influenza pandemic killed an estimated 50 to 100 million people worldwide. In October 1918, sparks from a passing train ignited fields near Cloquet and Moose Lake, Minnesota.

Four hundred and fifty people were killed in an area that spanned 1,500 square miles. There were 21,000 injuries and 52,000 displaced people, said Curt Brown, a journalist and the author of "Minnesota, 1918." The aftermath made it easy to spread disease.

Jobless

From A1

affecting nearly 2.7 billion workers — about 81 percent of the global workforce — the agency said.

Around half a billion people could sink into poverty as a result of the economic fallout from the coronavirus unless richer countries act to help developing nations, Oxfam, a leading aid organization, warned Thursday.

In the United States, the job market is quickly unraveling as businesses have shut down across the country. All told, in the past three weeks, 16.8 million Americans have filed for unemployment aid.

The surge of jobless claims has overwhelmed state unemployment offices around the country. And still more job cuts are expected.

More than 20 million people may lose jobs this month.

The unemployment rate could hit 15% when the April employment report is released in early May.

"The carnage in the American labor market continued unabated," said Joseph Brusuelas, chief economist for RSM, a tax advisory firm.

The viral outbreak is believed to have erased nearly one-third of the U.S. economy's output in the current quarter. Forty-eight states have closed non-essential businesses.

A nation of normally free-spending shoppers and travelers is mainly hunkered down at home, bringing entire gears of the economy to a near-halt. Non-grocery retail business plunged 97% in the last week of March compared with a year earlier, according to Morgan Stanley.

The number of airline passengers screened by the Transportation Security Administration has plunged 95% from a year ago. U.S. hotel revenue has tumbled 80%.

Meanwhile, New York state reported a record-breaking number of dead for a third straight day, 799.

More than 7,000 people have died in the state, accounting for almost half the U.S. death toll of more than 16,000.

"That is so shocking and painful and breathtaking, I don't even have the words for it," New York Gov. Andrew Cuomo said. But he added that there are hopeful signs, including slowdowns in the number of people being hospitalized, admitted to intensive care and placed on ventilators.

Worldwide, the number of dead topped 95,000 and confirmed infections reached about 1.6 million, according to Johns Hopkins University, though the true numbers are believed much higher, in part because of different rules for counting the dead and cover-ups by some governments.

On Capitol Hill, the Senate twisted itself into knots Thursday over President Donald Trump's new coronavirus aid request, as Democrats refused to rubber stamp his proposal for $250 billion more to boost small businesses, demanding modifications along with an additional $250 billion for health care providers and states.

Republicans wouldn't go along.

The standoff doesn't end the pursuit of more rescue funds, but it came as the government reported that 6.6 million more people filed for unemployment benefits last week, increasing worries that the economy is sliding toward a severe recession.

The small business program at issue is off to a rocky rollout.

GOP leader Mitch McConnell sought to keep Thursday's debate limited to Trump's request and wouldn't accept Democratic additions. Even if the GOP plan had succeeded in the Senate, the Democratic-controlled House is determined to make changes to ensure small businesses in minority communities benefit from the burst of government funding.

Democrats and Republicans agree the aid is urgently needed and talks are sure to continue, but it reinforces that Congress and the White House will need to find bipartisan agreement — especially with lawmakers scattered in their states and districts and both the House and Senate unable to conduct roll-call votes.

House Speaker Nancy Pelosi declared the Senate vote merely a "stunt" as the country faces an "epic" crisis. She ridiculed the administration for trying to jam a $250 billion request through Congress with 48 hours notice with little data to back it up.

The stall comes as communities across the nation strain to meet health care needs and salvage local economies pummeled by the crisis.

Microreactor

From A1

it's based on highly unreasonable assumptions about what nuclear power can and can't do."

He said the push for the microreactors is being driven by companies that want to build them as opposed to the military wanting them.

Comments are being taken through April 30 to develop an environmental impact statement on the plan. The Defense Department said the specific design of the prototype microreactor won't be known while preparing an environmental review, so impacts from a variety of designs will be considered. The department said the prototype is expected to be a small advanced gas reactor using enriched uranium for fuel and would be air-cooled.

The type of enriched uranium to be used would be encapsulated and can withstand high temperature, allowing for a safe prototype reactor. The Nuclear Regulatory Commission is participating in the project as a safety and security regulator.

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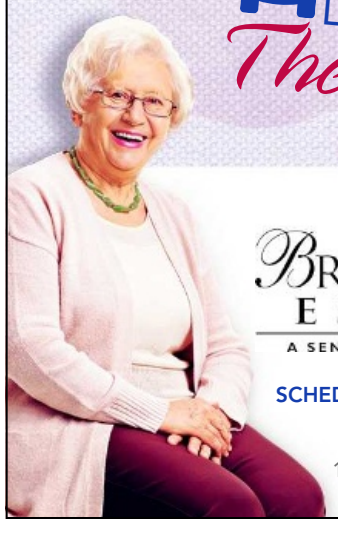
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